

to prevent the onset of scurvy, a potentially fatal vitamin C deficiency marked by bleeding of the gums.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Besides having a high vitamin C content, scurvy grass has antiseptic and mild laxative actions. The young plant, which has a general detoxicant effect and contains a wide range of minerals, is taken as a spring tonic. Like watercress (*Nasturtium officinale*, p. 239), it has diuretic properties and is useful for any condition in which poor nutrition is a factor. It can be used in the form of a juice as an antiseptic mouthwash for canker sores, and can also be applied externally to spots and pimples.

Cocos nucifera (Arecaceae)

Coconut, Coconut Palm

Description Too familiar to need description, the coconut is a large palm reaching up to 100 ft (30 m) in height with a single, smooth trunk and long-ribbed leaves up to 20 ft (6 m) in length.

Habitat & Cultivation Thought to have originated in Southeast Asia, coconut is now found throughout the tropics. It thrives in sandy, salty soils (typically coastal) and requires abundant sun and rain. Propagated by seed, the one-seeded nut grows out through one of the three germinating pores at its base. In 2009, coconut was grown commercially in 80 countries, with a total production of 61.7 million tons. A coconut palm can produce up to 10,000 nuts during its lifetime.

Parts Used Kernel (fresh or dried), water. Every part of coconut is useful.



Coconut palms have spread across the tropical regions of the globe. The oil has antimicrobial properties.

Constituents Coconut oil is about 90% saturated fat, mostly medium-chain fatty acids (lauric, myristic, caprylic, and capric acids). Coconut water contains significant levels of minerals, notably potassium. Virgin coconut oil is entirely non-toxic.

History & Folklore The coconut palm is described as “Kalpavriksha” (meaning “the all-giving tree”) in ancient Indian texts.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Coconut oil and cream have established antimicrobial and immunostimulant activity. With antibacterial, antifungal, and antiviral properties, the oil and cream can be used to counter many commonly occurring infections, such as influenza, cold sores, shingles, and fungal problems. Coconut has a beneficial action on the gut flora and can prove useful (alongside other treatment) in clearing intestinal worms and parasites. Coconut oil and cream aid digestion and the absorption of nutrients (notably calcium and magnesium), and may be taken as part of a regimen to prevent or treat osteoporosis. Coconut water is reported to lower blood pressure, in part due to its high potassium content, while the oil helps prevent arteriosclerosis. It is also thought to lower cholesterol levels, aid weight loss, and lower blood glucose levels. Coconut oil helps keep skin and hair healthy and is a common ingredient in skin creams and shampoos. Coconut merits its name of “all-giving tree.”

Coffea arabica (Rubiaceae)

Coffee

Description Evergreen shrub or small tree growing to 30 ft (9 m). Has dark green, shiny oval leaves and white star-shaped flowers. Produces small red fruit, each containing 2 seeds (beans).

Habitat & Cultivation Coffee is native to tropical East Africa, and is now cultivated in tropical areas worldwide. The best-quality beans are produced by fermenting, sun-drying, and roasting the seeds.

Parts Used Seeds.

Constituents Coffee contains chlorogenic acids, tannins, and xanthines—caffeine (0.6–0.32%), theobromine, and theophylline. Caffeine is a strong stimulant. Theophylline is a stimulant and smooth muscle relaxant. Chlorogenic acids are anti-inflammatory.

History & Folklore Native to the plateaus of central Ethiopia, where it is thought to have originated, coffee spread to Yemen in the 6th century CE and then on into the Arabian peninsula. The Arabian physician Rhazes first recorded coffee's use in the 10th century CE. While coffee drinking formed part of Sufi prayer rituals, being taken to enable longer, more ecstatic prayer through the night, coffee gradually became



Coffee, native to East Africa, can be used to relieve headaches.

the popular stimulant drink that we know today, spreading to Europe in the 17th century. By 2015, the annual trade in coffee exceeded \$10 billion.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Coffee is an effective and much-loved stimulant of central nervous function, aiding mental alertness and perception. Coffee (and extracts) increase physical performance and heart output, stimulate digestive juices, and act as a powerful diuretic. It can be taken to counter drowsiness and to relieve headaches and migraines. It is non-addictive, although excess intake or sudden withdrawal from coffee may cause headaches. Many natural medicine practitioners consider overuse of coffee to be unhealthy as it is associated with nervous and endocrine exhaustion. Decaffeinated green coffee bean extract is taken to promote weight loss.

Research Regular coffee drinking is associated with a significantly decreased risk of colon cancer. Coffee may have a protective effect against Alzheimer's and Parkinson's diseases.

Cautions Percolated or boiled coffee is thought to have potentially harmful effects on the heart and circulation and to raise cholesterol levels. Caffeine can increase pre-menstrual symptoms and period pains.

Cola acuminata (Sterculiaceae)

Kola Nut, Cola Nut

Description Evergreen tree growing to 65 ft (20 m) with dark green leaves and yellowish-white flowers. Large woody seed pods contain 5–10 white or red seeds (nuts).

Habitat & Cultivation Native to West Africa, kola nut is cultivated widely in the tropics, especially in Nigeria, Brazil, and the West Indies.